

Word family: **spiral / spirals / spiralled / spiraled / spiralling / spiraling / spiral-shaped / downward spiral**

Base word: spiral

Part of speech: **noun, verb, adjective**

Related forms:

* **spiral** (n.) — 螺旋；螺旋形；惡性循環 / 連鎖惡化

* **spiral** (v.) — 螺旋式移動；急劇上升 / 下降；逐步失控

* **spiral** (adj.) — 螺旋形的

* **spiralled / spiraled** — spiral 的過去式 / 過去分詞

* **spiralling / spiraling** — 螺旋上升 / 下降；持續惡化

* **spiral-shaped** — 螺旋形的

* **downward spiral** — 惡性循環；不斷惡化

* **upward spiral** — 良性上升循環；持續上升

* **spiral out of control** — 逐步失控；迅速惡化至無法控制

* **spiral upwards / downwards** — 螺旋上升 / 下降；急升 / 急跌

BrE / AmE spelling:

* BrE: **spiralled, spiralling**

* AmE: **spiraled, spiraling**

Meaning in this passage

> ...now I know how to get back on track before everything **spirals out of control**.

Here, **spirals out of control** is figurative.

It means:

a problem begins getting progressively worse until it becomes difficult or impossible to manage — 情況不斷惡化，最後失去控制

The speaker may procrastinate a little, but now they can recover before one delay causes another, deadlines pile up, stress increases, and everything becomes chaotic again.

中文翻譯：

現在的我知道怎樣在事情**逐步惡化至失控**之前，重新把自己拉回正軌。

So here:

spiral out of control = 問題一環扣一環地變得越來越嚴重，最後失去控制

1. **spiral (noun : 螺旋形) — 螺旋；螺旋形**

The core literal sense.

Practice 1

> The shell has a beautiful **spiral**.

這個貝殼有漂亮的**螺旋形紋路**。

Practice 2

> Draw a **spiral** from the centre of the page.

從頁面中央畫一個**螺旋**。

Practice 3

> The pattern forms a **spiral**.

這個圖案形成一個**螺旋形**。

MCQ-ready definition:

spiral = 一條圍繞中心逐漸向外或向內彎曲的線或形狀

2. **spiral-shaped — 螺旋形的**

Practice 1

> The staircase is **spiral-shaped**.

樓梯是**螺旋形的**。

Practice 2

> The plant has **spiral-shaped leaves**.

這種植物有**螺旋形葉片**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****spiral-shaped = 外形像螺旋般圍繞中心彎曲的****

3. ****spiral staircase — 螺旋樓梯****

A very common compound.

Practice 1

> We climbed the narrow ****spiral staircase****.

我們爬上狹窄的****螺旋樓梯****。

Practice 2

> A ****spiral staircase**** connects the two floors.

一條****螺旋樓梯****連接兩層樓。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiral staircase = 圍繞中央軸心向上盤旋的樓梯****

4. ****spiral notebook / spiral-bound notebook — 螺旋裝記事簿****

Practice 1

> I bought a ****spiral notebook**** for my notes.

我買了一本****螺旋裝記事簿****來做筆記。

Practice 2

> The pages are held together by a ****spiral binding****.

頁面由****螺旋裝訂****固定在一起。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiral-bound = 用螺旋金屬線或塑膠圈裝訂的****

5. ****spiral (verb : 螺旋式移動) — 盤旋 ; 螺旋移動****

Practice 1

> Smoke **spiralled upward** into the sky.

煙霧**盤旋上升**到天空。

Practice 2

> The bird **spiralled down** towards the ground.

那隻鳥**盤旋下降**至地面。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiral = 沿着螺旋形路線移動****

6. **spiral upwards / downwards — 盤旋上升 / 下降**

Practice 1

> Leaves **spiralled downwards** from the tree.

樹葉**打着旋兒飄落**。

Practice 2

> The aircraft **spiralled upwards**.

飛機**盤旋上升**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiral upwards/downwards = 一邊旋轉，一邊向上或向下移動****

7. **spiral (figurative : 數字急升) — 急劇上升；不斷攀升**

A major figurative sense.

Practice 1

> Costs began to **spiral**.

成本開始**急劇上升**。

Practice 2

> House prices **spiralled upwards**.

樓價**不斷急升**。

MCQ-ready definition:

spiral = 數字、成本、價格等迅速而持續地上升

8. **spiralling costs / prices** — 不斷飆升的成本 / 價格

Practice 1

> The company struggled with **spiralling costs**.

公司難以應付**不斷飆升的成本**。

Practice 2

> Families are worried about **spiralling prices**.

家庭擔心**持續急升的物價**。

MCQ-ready definition:

spiralling costs/prices = 持續而快速上升的成本 / 價格

9. **spiral downward** — 急劇下降；一路惡化

Practice 1

> Sales began to **spiral downward**.

銷售額開始**急劇下滑**。

Practice 2

> His confidence **spiralled downward** after repeated failures.

多次失敗後，他的自信**一路下降**。

MCQ-ready definition:

spiral downward = 數量、情況或狀態持續而快速下降

10. ****spiral out of control — 逐步失控；惡化至無法控制****

This is the exact expression used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> I know how to get back on track before everything ****spirals out of control****.

我知道怎樣在一切****惡化至失控****前重回正軌。

Practice 2

> A small disagreement can ****spiral out of control**** if nobody deals with it.

如果沒有人處理，一場小分歧也可能****逐步惡化至失控****。

Practice 3

> My workload ****spiralled out of control**** during exam week.

考試周期間，我的工作量****迅速變得失控****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiral out of control = 問題持續擴大或惡化，最後變得難以管理****

11. ****spiral into something — 逐步陷入某種狀態****

A major figurative construction.

Practice 1

> The argument ****spiralled into chaos****.

爭吵逐漸****演變成混亂局面****。

Practice 2

> The company ****spiralled into debt****.

公司逐步****陷入債務困境****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiral into X = 情況逐步惡化並最終進入 X 的負面狀態****

12. ****spiral into chaos — 演變成混亂****

Practice 1

> Without clear leadership, the meeting ****spiralled into chaos****.

沒有清楚領導，會議逐漸****陷入混亂****。

Practice 2

> The schedule ****spiralled into chaos**** after several delays.

數次延誤後，時間表逐步****變得一團糟****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiral into chaos = 一連串問題令情況越來越亂，最後失去秩序****

13. ****spiral into debt — 陷入債務惡化****

Practice 1

> Unexpected expenses caused him to ****spiral into debt****.

突如其來的開支令他逐步****陷入債務****。

Practice 2

> Poor financial decisions can make debt ****spiral****.

不良財務決定可能令債務****愈滾愈大****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiral into debt = 債務因持續增加而越來越難控制****

14. ****spiral into crisis — 逐步陷入危機****

Practice 1

> The situation quickly ****spiralled into crisis****.

情況迅速****演變成危機****。

Practice 2

> Poor planning allowed a minor issue to ****spiral into a crisis****.

規劃不善令一個小問題逐步****演變成危機****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiral into crisis = 問題逐步加劇，最後形成嚴重危機****

15. ****downward spiral — 惡性循環；不斷惡化****

A very important noun expression.

Practice 1

> Stress and procrastination can create a ****downward spiral****.

壓力和拖延可以形成一個****惡性循環****。

Practice 2

> The company entered a ****downward spiral**** of falling sales and rising debt.

公司陷入銷售下降、債務上升的****惡性循環****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****downward spiral = 一個負面因素引發另一個負面因素，令情況不斷惡化的循環****

16. ****be caught in a downward spiral — 陷入惡性循環****

Practice 1

> He became ****caught in a downward spiral**** of stress and poor sleep.

他陷入了壓力與睡眠不足的****惡性循環****。

Practice 2

> The business was **caught in a downward spiral**.

這間公司**陷入持續惡化的局面**。

MCQ-ready definition:

be caught in a downward spiral = 被困在一個越來越糟、難以自行停止的負面循環中

17. **upward spiral** — 良性上升循環；持續改善

The opposite metaphor.

Practice 1

> Better habits created an **upward spiral** of confidence and productivity.

更好的習慣帶來了自信與生產力不斷提升的**良性循環**。

Practice 2

> Success can sometimes create an **upward spiral** of motivation.

成功有時能形成動力持續增加的**良性循環**。

MCQ-ready definition:

upward spiral = 一個正面改善帶來另一個改善，令整體狀況不斷向好的循環

18. **spiralling problem** — 持續惡化的問題

Practice 1

> The team struggled to control the **spiralling problem**.

團隊難以控制這個**不斷惡化的問題**。

Practice 2

> The government faced **spiralling costs** and shortages.

政府面對**不斷上升的成本**和短缺。

MCQ-ready definition:

****spiralling X = 正在以越來越嚴重或快速的方式發展的 X****

19. ****spiral (figurative : 情緒 / 心理狀態越來越差) — 情緒失控 ; 越陷越深****

Common informal modern use.

Practice 1

> After reading the message, she started to ****spiral****.

看完訊息後，她開始****越想越焦慮 / 情緒逐漸失控****。

Practice 2

> I was tired and stressed, and I could feel myself ****spiralling****.

我又累又有壓力，感覺自己開始****越來越失控****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiral = informal: 情緒或思緒進入越來越負面、焦慮或難以控制的狀態****

20. ****spiralling thoughts / anxiety — 不斷惡化的思緒 / 焦慮****

Practice 1

> She couldn't stop her ****spiralling thoughts****.

她無法停止那些****越想越失控的思緒****。

Practice 2

> Lack of sleep made his anxiety ****spiral****.

睡眠不足令他的焦慮****愈來愈嚴重****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****spiralling thoughts/anxiety = 負面思緒或焦慮不斷自我加劇****

Important distinction 1: ****spiral vs circle****

circle

move around at roughly the same distance from a centre.

spiral

move around while also moving inward/outward/up/down.

> circle the building

> 繞着建築物轉

> spiral upward

> 一邊旋轉一邊上升

Important distinction 2: **spiral vs spin**

spin

rotate around your own axis.

spiral

follow a curved path around a centre while changing distance or height.

A coin can **spin** in one place; smoke can **spiral upward**.

Important distinction 3: **spiral vs rise**

rise

simply increase.

spiral

often suggests **rapid, continuing, and potentially hard-to-control increase**.

> prices rose

> 價格上升

> prices spiralled

> 價格**急劇飆升**

So ****spiral**** is much more vivid.

Important distinction 4: ****spiral vs fall****

****fall****

decrease.

****spiral downward****

decrease rapidly and continuously, often with worsening consequences.

> sales fell

> 銷售下降

> sales spiralled downward

> 銷售****一路急跌****

Important distinction 5: ****spiral out of control vs lose control****

****lose control****

control is lost.

****spiral out of control****

emphasizes a ****process**** where things progressively worsen before control is lost.

This progression is crucial in your passage.

Important distinction 6: ****spiral into X vs turn into X****

****turn into X****

general transformation.

****spiral into X****

gradual worsening with momentum.

> disagreement turned into an argument

> 分歧變成爭吵

> disagreement spiralled into a major conflict

> 分歧**一路惡化成重大衝突**

Important distinction 7: **downward spiral vs vicious circle**

They overlap strongly but emphasize slightly different things.

downward spiral

continuous worsening over time.

vicious circle / vicious cycle

A causes B, and B feeds back into A.

Example:

> stress → procrastination → more stress

can be both:

* a **vicious cycle**

* a **downward spiral**

Important distinction 8: **upward spiral vs virtuous cycle**

Similarly:

upward spiral

emphasizes continuing improvement.

virtuous cycle

emphasizes positive feedback between causes.

Important distinction 9: **spiralling costs vs inflation**

spiralling costs

descriptive: costs are rising rapidly.

inflation

an economic concept referring to a broad increase in general price levels.

Not every spiralling cost is inflation.

Important distinction 10: **spiral as noun vs verb**

Noun:

> a spiral

> 一個螺旋

> a downward spiral

> 惡性循環

Verb:

> prices spiralled

> 價格急升

> the situation spiralled out of control

> 情況逐漸失控

Same metaphor, different grammar.

Important distinction 11: **spiral can describe positive or negative movement**

Negative is much more common figuratively:

> costs spiral

> debt spirals

> situation spirals out of control

But positive is possible:

> upward spiral of confidence

So ****spiral** itself does not inherently mean bad******; direction and context matter.

Important distinction 12: ****spiral** in mental-health-style informal language******

Modern informal English sometimes uses:

> I'm spiralling.

to mean:

****我的焦慮 / 負面想法開始越來越失控****

This is stronger than simply:

> I'm worried.

It suggests self-reinforcing deterioration.

Important distinction 13: ****BrE vs AmE spelling****

British English:

* ****spiralled****

* ****spiralling****

American English:

* ****spiraled****

* ****spiraling****

Both are standard.

For IELTS-style British English, ****spiralled / spiralling**** is a natural choice.

Family-extension note

****Spiral**** begins with a physical shape:

****movement around a centre while moving progressively inward/outward/up/down****

That physical pattern creates a powerful figurative metaphor:

each stage leads into another stage, creating momentum

This gives us:

1. **physical shape**

- * a spiral
- * spiral staircase

2. **physical movement**

- * spiral upwards
- * spiral downwards

3. **rapid numerical movement**

- * spiralling prices
- * costs spiral upward

4. **progressive deterioration**

- * spiral out of control
- * spiral into crisis

5. **feedback patterns**

- * downward spiral
- * upward spiral

6. **emotional deterioration**

- * start spiralling
- * spiralling anxiety

For your passage, the exact meaning is:

a small setback triggers further problems until the whole situation becomes unmanageable

Master comparison

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spiral (noun)	螺旋；螺旋形	physical shape
spiral-shaped	螺旋形的	shape
spiral staircase	螺旋樓梯	physical structure
spiral-bound	螺旋裝訂的	binding
spiral (movement)	盤旋；螺旋移動	curved movement
spiral upwards	盤旋上升	physical/increase
spiral downwards	盤旋下降	physical/decrease
prices spiral	價格急升	rapid increase
spiralling costs	不斷飆升的成本	uncontrolled increase
spiral downward	急劇下降	worsening/decrease
spiral out of control	惡化至失控	progressive loss of control
spiral into chaos	逐步陷入混亂	worsening state
spiral into debt	陷入債務	worsening debt
spiral into crisis	演變成危機	deterioration
downward spiral	惡性循環	continuing decline
upward spiral	良性上升循環	continuing improvement
spiral (emotion)	情緒逐漸失控	mental deterioration
spiralling thoughts	不斷惡化的負面思緒	self-reinforcing thoughts

For your original sentence

> ...but the difference is that now I know how to get back on track before everything **spirals out of control**.

Here:

spirals out of control = 一開始可能只是一點拖延，但如果不處理，就會變成工作積壓、截止日期逼近、壓力增加，再引發更多拖延，最後整個生活節奏失控

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 但不同的是，現在的我知道怎樣在事情**一步一步惡化至失控**之前，重新把自己拉回正軌。

The sentence actually contains a beautiful metaphorical contrast:

> **get back on track** = 回到正確路線

> **spiral out of control** = **問題愈滾愈大，逐步失控**

So the speaker is saying:

I may still drift off course, but I now recover before one small problem starts feeding another and turns into chaos.